IDF army chief defends censorship over Tomer Eiges' death

By **The Editorial** - 9 June 2021

Tomer Eiges in undated photo.

Israeli General Staff Chief Aviv Kohavi defended the IDF's decision on Wednesday to censor information about the death of Tomer Eiges (25), an intelligence officer in the military prison. Eiges was detained for serious national security crimes.

Although the military has since lifted parts of the gag order related to the case, many details still cannot be published in Israeli media. Including the identity of the officer and the specific nature of his alleged crimes.

However, his name is widely shared online after it was unintentionally revealed in a chat room of prison staff.

Eiges was arrested last year and charged in September. He had not yet been convicted, but was in prison while his lawyers and military prosecutors were negotiating a possible plea deal. On the night of May 16, he was found in his cell in serious condition and taken to a hospital, where he was pronounced dead a few hours later.

Although an autopsy was performed – with a doctor present on behalf of the family –, no official cause of death has yet been determined according to the IDF. Military officials indicate that it is a suicide, but relatives of Eiges doubt that he was able to do so.

In his speech, Kohavi said that the officer had almost caused damage to a state secret, but the damage was prevented at the last minute.

"The military intelligence officer was my soldier. The military intelligence officer was a soldier for all of us, even though he committed a very serious crime. He committed them consciously. He committed them deliberately, for reasons I cannot describe. I'm very sorry, Kohavi said.

Earlier this week, the military said that Tomer Eiges had worked alone and had not acted on behalf of a foreign government or for financial gain or ideology, but out of unspecified 'personal motivations'.

"The officer cooperated with his interrogation and admitted most of the acts he was accused of", the military said.

The IDF said that the officer was not in solitary confinement at the time of his death, but in a normal cell with other prisoners. The IDF added that the officer in prison could speak and see his family and friends.

After the death of the Eiges, two internal investigations into the case were launched within the IDF Manpower Directorate, one of them looked at the specific case of the soldier and another looked more generally at the army's prison system, specifically "prisoners with special characteristics", the IDF said.

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